

GAIM was first written in 1999 by an Auburn University student, Mark Spencer. In his own words, “I wrote GAIM as an exercise in how to write my own instant messenger,” then he made the software available to other Linux users. But it has not been smooth sailing for GAIM, after AOL raised an objection to GAIM, stating that the latter had “copied” some trademarks. In the true spirit of the open source community, GAIM users donated money with which the GAIM developers sought the services of law students to arrive at a negotiation with AOL.

With GAIM around, frankly, you don’t need any other messenger. But then, Linux is not about any one product. So we shall briefly tell you about other IM clients that work on Linux.

AIM

AOL Instant Messenger is one of the oldest messenger services till date. AOL does not update the Linux version of the client often. Nevertheless, if you want to try AIM on Linux, you can visit <http://www.aim.com/> and click on the Download button, and choose “Linux”.

aMSN

No, that’s not a typo—alvaroMSN, or aMSN, is what we are talking about. It is a free, open source MSN Messenger clone featuring display images, creating custom emoticons, Webcam support, and several usable features. And if you are learning foreign languages, aMSN supports around 40 languages. It also has a tabbed window feature where every chat window appears as a tab instead of opening a separate window. You can add skins and change the look of aMSN. The current version available is 0.95 with the release date December 25, 2005. You can download it from <http://amsn.sourceforge.net/download.php>

Yahoo!

Yahoo! Messenger is available for Linux too. Just go to <http://messenger.yahoo.com/> and near the bottom of the page, look for small-sized text that says “other versions”. Click on “Unix”. There